

Chapter 4

CALLING THE SHOTS...

"Lorain, girl what happened!" Kat shouted as she saw me rush inside and lock the door behind me with Thomas walking up to her.

"Any Guests?" I yelled. "No." Kat replied,,, I was just about to sit down when I saw Tom still shaking from what had just happened to him, ,, "Kat, Make this guy something to eat, he's the new guy at the petrol station and they just got robbed." "Please just sit down!", Kat said in a soft voice, "You can't leave this guy standing on his two feet. He's been doing that for over half a day already it seems."

We huddled into the bar at the back, it was only 16:00 o'clock and the mood was sour, i gestured at the sofa and table at the the back, and he moved, almost effortlessly in its direction and fell down on the cushions and slumped over the table with his head in his hands "You want a drink" i said loudly, letting him know i wouldn't take no for an answer.

I left him there to quiet down and made my way behind the bar and took out a beer I had been saving for over half a year that was hidden behind the other bottles in the refrigerator, and fumbled for the opener on the bar, and walked back to him.

A shhhhh of frying potatoes rang out from the kitchen and we both heard Kat's voice "Fish AND Chips, soon." calling us from the kitchen.

"Okay pal", i said to the guy as i sat down in one of the chairs in front of the table across from where he lay slumped over burying his face in his jacket "chin up, you are alive, that's what counts" "and you still got your phone and keys i saw," ...

I opened the bottle for him and said he oughta drink it.

He lifted his head, put his back straight and took a huge sip.

I said "look i dont know what you know, but knowing the police around this part of the highway, best bet is I call your boss and we pull a few strings, and you get a bit of cash and a vacation" "If you'll let me talk to them."

He looked me in the eye, and a spark of anger glinted in his eyes.

"Yea" he said "anything that'll get me paid" "or at least....Another Job.", "But I must tell the authorities too, they cut the alarm somehow, maybe last night; I don't know." ...

"Call em" I said "Tell them their security sucks and even gas stations aren't safe" "and that you'd be lucky to get a paycheck after what just happened to the goddamn place."

He took another gulp of beer and said "okay 911" and picked his pocket for his phone. And started dialing.

"Yes Hello?" He said, "This Thomas Renkler i need to report a robbery at the gas station BP the small one off on the rural road to the city on the turn off along the highway by myalup state forest" "I work there"" "yes the alarm was bypassed , I couldn't do nothing at all but just sit, get gagged and tied up, by two bikers" , , , "You'll see what you can do?" "GREAT THANKS!" he hung up.. "You were right Lorain, they can't do anything for me..."

I looked at him, and gave him a short smile and said, "look even if they could help you what's done is done, and more important is that you eat some food and finish your drink, I stared at him as he looked me straight in the eye, "you're serious" he said in a voice like he was more scared of me that of what just had happened. "You really want to pull those strings with my boss?" "I nodded and asked for his phone, "Don't worry "I said "I'll put us on -Loud speaker so you can talk too, but let me tell it like it is." "I saved your ass kinda, or i can save your ass from not getting paid if you let me".

He nodded and handed me his unlocked phone and said : "Yes, please, call" ...

He finished his beer. And told me the contact name.

The phone dialed 'PetrolStation-BossHenry' as I put it on Loud speaker, A voice answered in a surprised fashion "Yes Hello, This Henry? Who's calling"

Thomas immediately answered : "It's me Tom!" I interrupted Henry's Reply "To-" "Yeah your lousy security just got your petrol station robbed!" "I yapped at the phone not giving Henry time to ask any questions or even comment , "I just saved Tom from being gagged and bound like a hog at a hogroast, two bikers apparently done it ! "

The line was silent for a few moments "Shit okay where are you now?" Henry asked? "We are safe" , I said "more important is who cleans up this mess, and if Thomas can expect compensation for this incident" I genuinely frowned visibly down the phone line at the camera image of me holding the phone and the contact name that Tom had on his phone "Yes I see," Henry said "Of course I'll see to it he gets a compensation claim check, and leave until further notice" .

"Good thanks, here talk to Tom!" , , "Hello Boss" Tom said as he grabbed the phone back from me" and tried to look seriously happy that I had taken the word "Okay Tom he said , are you okay?" "Yes Boss" "You'll get a final check next week, until further notice" "Thank you!" Tom Replied, then the phone went dead like some horror movie that ends on a cliff hanger, "He hung up" Tom said in an astonished voice. And then looked back down at his phone and put it on the table.

You live in Perth don't you " I asked , He responded : "Not in-but close by yeah, my brother drives me to work, was our plan,,," "it was"....., "i just was on the second month, i saw you pass by almost every day Lorain!"

"Yeah guy, I saw you too" I said, trying not to sound shy.

Kat joined us, three plates in hand and we ate hungrily exchanging few words. She squirted the ketchup on her fries as we munched at the small plates with cod and chips, and looked up frowning into the void and swallowed her bite of fish. "Still one week left till your Rock and Roll band makes their debut, let's hope we can do it outside and this storm doesn't hit us too hard, honey." Kat remarked. "Yeah sweetie," I replied, looking at Tom as he stared at his meal while eating it. "By the way..." Kat enquired, "wasn't their manager or sound guy coming to stake out the place later on today?" "Yes at 6 I said, he should be here soon." still looking at Thomas I asked him "So What are you gonna do?" , "Call my Brother to come pick me up here" he said, "whats the name of this place any way?"

I looked in my shoulder bag and grabbed a flyer for the party next Saturday, and handed it to him. "The place is just called 'highway motel' it keeps us off the radar" i exclaimed "places like this are a dime a dozen past the highways on the coast, but we have a bar and restaurant and try to do a gig with music , live music , every three months or so" "You are invited , no need for a ticket, just bring the flyer if you can!"

Our plates were now empty, it was a quarter to six and Tom had made that call to his brother , sharing his google maps location as he needed that ride home, he decided to just go walk to the highway intersection and wait for his brother since it was good weather and the sunset over the beach is beautiful i had said" He left belly full , another lonely soul waiting for his driver, his ride home, i looked at him grow distant in the the view from my doorway and then headed back in and left the door unlocked, "So this guy the roady soundtech manager guy i think he said his name was Ralph or Ronald or something" "I'll recognize him; he video called me a week ago asking if we could accommodate a band" I said to Kat who was sitting in the lobby chair turning the radio dial till she found a news station. The Radio Crackled: "So this weekend seems packed with possible thunderstorms and definite hurricane wind warnings, as harbours redirect and air traffic will be grounded for the -foreseeable future starting with delays on outbound flights this Saturday night." "and now for some music from the nineties to drown your lovesickness and disco pride ego in" "The Cure - Pictures of -you....." She turned the music off and the radio fell silent. "Lets hope that the roof on top here doesn't blow off" Kat said and sighed....

Yeash i sure hope she dont blow off, I thought turning back to the doorway at the sound of a car pulling up in the driveway, Look lively I thought, a customer or that roady for sure...

Two people stepped out I could see from the window, a guy in his mid thirties or forties, and a woman about 30 years old. Judging by the mugshot of Ralph or Ronalds face I had seen earlier last week on my phone , it was him and ?? a partner? Cute, I thought.

They pulled out their luggage and stepped into our lobby, as if they needed a drink, some music and a room in the back where they could make out and tell each other bedtime stories...

"Hey Lorain" he said looking at me behind the makeshift lobby desk, it wasn't a lobby desk at all really it was something we had put together from old tables and table cloths with a laptop, a phone and a note block and pen , Our guest list... "It is Lorain isn't it ? or are we in the wrong motel?" I laughed out loud "No! "I said "You're Ronald right? "Actualy the names Roland , he said and his girlfriend giggled as he said it , "I get that allot Ronald, Roland,,," "don't worry and yes we are here to set up the stage for the band next weekend"! "Yep," i said "just gonna be one rough few nights ahead tomorrow and sunday, you must have heard"

"Yes" Roland said Waving hello to kat in the chair, and looking back at me, "the gear won't be here till Wednesday , Thursday at latest, i think the storm will have passed by then" he smiled and the lady at his side did the same "did you get that CD I sent by mail?"

"Yes I did actually just yesterday, I haven't had time to listen to it yet, lets get you into your room anyways, and you can join us for some food and drinks in the bar after" i gestured towards the wooden doorway with a black and red draw curtain instead of an actual door and said: "that's the bar, but there's plenty of room outdoors too if it gets busy or if they just prefer doing the gig outdoors" ..

We stepped up the staircase and I showed them their room.